

Search For Moe Berg

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NEW YORK—(NEA)—George Jessel was given an impossible task. As chairman of the U.S. Committee for Baseball in Israel, he was asked to fly to Tel Aviv with the first baseball equipment that country had seen. Which was easy enough. The hard part came when his group asked him to find Moe Berg, the old catcher.

"They want Berg to spend eight months teaching the kids over there how to play baseball," George was saying. "But how am I going to find him?"

Berg, for 20 years a short-stop, catcher for coach with the White Sox and Red Sox, speaks eight languages, has three or four different degrees and would create a riot head of an Israeli baseball school.

IT IS NORMALLY easier to find new money than Berg. The Yankees, once seeking Moe for an Old Timer's game had to have Mel Allen request over TV that people look for him. A bridge toll collector at Orient Point, L.I., came up with Moe that time. But usually it is impossible to locate the combination walk-

ing encyclopedia and detective magazine

Jessel, however, appears to be well qualified.

When John McGraw was manager of the New York Giants one of his major aims was to find a Jewish ballplayers. The gate possibilities, McGraw figured, would be unlimited with such an attraction.

SO WHEN A SECOND baseman named Andy Cohen arrived in the 1928 season, and started off at a murderous clip, McGraw was elated. "We," he said to George Jessel, a Giant batboy in 1910, "have it made."

But they started to curve Cohen after a time and one afternoon Jessel watched as Andy struck out for the second time with men on base and the Giants were routed, 8-0

After the game he and McGraw hustled to Belmont Park to catch the last half of the day's card and in the seventh race a considerable bundle was put on a horse ridden by Sammy Renick. The horse got no place and McGraw was particularly displeased with Sammy's ride.

Jessel glumly leaned over to him. "John," he said softly,

make up for it.

THE CHICAGO CARDINALS draw a blank on the form chart. A complete coaching overhaul brought Frank Ivy down from the Canadian game with some Oklahoma-influenced variations of the T. A bevy of trades face-lifted the offensive and defensive platoons. It's not even positive where they'll play King Hill and John Crow, their top draft choices. The only known quantity is Ollie Matscn, and that's a lot of football player.

No pro team is ever destitute.

"they can't ride, either."

"WE NEVER STOPED trying," Jessel says. "A couple of years later I dug up a guy named John Leiv. He was an Indian from the Haskel Institute, but McGraw thought we could put him over. But the boys covering the club began to suspect he wasn't Jewish. The other batters started to suspect he wasn't much of a pitcher."

Schmiel Itzek enthusiastically endorsed the idea Jessel and McGraw were trying to put over. Schmiel was a New York character who was always being kidded about his accent. Conscious of it, Schmiel would answer, "Vat's metter? Your m u d d e r and father vas Indians?"